scholars like Tan Yunshan and Wu Xiaoling, and artists like Xu Beihong.

The Chinese republican leader Sun Yat-sen avoided the open disparagement of India but argued that the British were a threat to China only because they had colonized India. According to him, India could be a springboard for a foreign power to attack China. It was not important in itself.

Chiang Kai-shek, China's wartime leader, was sympathetic to the Indian independence movement but was disappointed that the Congress Party was not ready to support the Allied counter-offensive against Japan in China. He paid a visit to India in February 1942 and met both Mahatma Gandhi and Nehru despite dissuasion from the British. He was conscious of the British instigating Hindu–Muslim division. In his diary he wrote that Jinnah was 'dishonest' and that 'it's not true that Hindus and Muslims can't get on'. He thought that 'truly patriotic Muslims' would stay with the Congress.[7]

Chiang's long meeting with Gandhi was a disappointment. He observed later that 'Gandhi knows and loves only India and doesn't care about other places and peoples'. In his view, India's 'traditional philosophy has made him this way. He only knows how to endure pain, and has no zeal – this is not the spirit of a revolutionary leader.'[8] Clearly, Chiang found Gandhi's ideas of non-violence and satyagraha not revolutionary and high-spirited enough. Even a sympathetic Chinese leader like Chiang saw Gandhi as a typically weak and even submissive Indian.

When Chiang's KMT forces were defeated and Mao established the PRC, India's prompt recognition of the new regime in Beijing soured whatever goodwill may have remained. Despite the Indian gesture, PRC leaders remained suspicious, initially dismissing India as remaining under Western influence despite having gained independence.

Wherever there were opportunities for direct engagement and conversation, the more prejudiced notions could be contested. Unfortunately, much of Chinese and Japanese readings of India during the first decades of the twentieth century were derived through translations of British colonial literature, which were openly and crudely racist in their depictions of India and its people. It is these mediated perceptions which